

EVIDENCE BRIEF · EDUCATION POLICY

Do school smartphone bans improve grades and mental health?

REFERENCES	STYLE	TOKENS	VERIFICATION	COMPILED
11 verified	Bullets	≈2.6k	Crossref	30 Aug 2026

SUMMARY

Bans reliably reduce phone use during school, but grades improve only modestly in some settings, and recent direct studies do not show better mental health. They are a classroom-management policy, not a proven wellbeing intervention.

01 Grades may improve slightly, but not consistently

- » A rapid review of five quantitative studies found a **small pooled benefit** across academic and social outcomes ($d = 0.162$), with fewer data for grades than for social outcomes.¹
- » An English policy study linked bans to a **0.07-standard-deviation** rise in high-stakes exam scores, concentrated among previously low-achieving pupils.²
- » A Spanish regional comparison reported sizeable maths and science gains in Galicia plus reduced bullying, but the non-random policy design cannot rule out every regional difference.³
- » Newer school comparisons were null: an Australian study found no between-group academic-engagement advantage after one month ($d = 0.03$, 95% confidence interval -0.14 to 0.20), while an English study found no English or maths attainment advantage.^{4,5}

02 Recent direct studies do not show better mental health

- » In 1,227 pupils across 30 English schools, restrictive policies did not improve wellbeing (adjusted difference -0.48, 95% CI -2.05 to 1.06), anxiety, or depression.⁵
- » The Australian pre-post study found no policy effect on psychological distress, life satisfaction, school belonging, or bullying.⁴
- » Among 1,398 Dutch pupils, full rather than classroom-only bans did not improve wellbeing or bullying; full bans were associated with weaker student-teacher connectedness and, among girls, lower school belonging.⁶
- » English focus groups found both positive and negative wellbeing pathways, shaped by enforcement, pupil agency, connectedness, learning, and home phone use.⁷

03 Bans change the school day more than pupils' overall exposure

- » Restrictive English schools cut phone use during school by **0.67 hours** (95% CI 0.43-0.92 fewer), yet weekday and weekend use did not differ.⁵
- » A four-week Danish recess ban increased moderate activity relative to sedentary time by a factor of **1.39**, but vigorous activity fell and 32.4% still reported using a phone during the intervention.⁸
- » The difference between immediate exposure and downstream outcomes is mapped in [Figure 1](#).

04 Policy design matters more than the word “ban”

- » A laboratory experiment found poorer recall when a phone was present, supporting distraction as a plausible mechanism, but its 119 participants were undergraduates rather than school pupils.⁹
- » A broader review linked heavier smartphone use to lower academic performance, yet judged the evidence heterogeneous and mainly non-causal.¹⁰
- » A systematic review of 60 classroom studies found educational phone use could help when teachers and pupils had the necessary digital and media skills.¹¹
- » The recurring pattern is an **exposure-outcome gap**: removing phones changes the school environment immediately, but better grades or mental health require more than reduced access during school hours.^{5,4}
- » The most defensible near-term promise is **less phone access during school**, not better overall mental health or a sustained fall in total phone use.⁵
- » Schools should define the outcome they want, monitor enforcement and workarounds, and assess learning and belonging separately. Current evidence does not justify using reduced school-day access as a proxy for broader success.^{5,7,4}
- » The policy differences hidden by the word “ban” are mapped in [Figure 2](#).

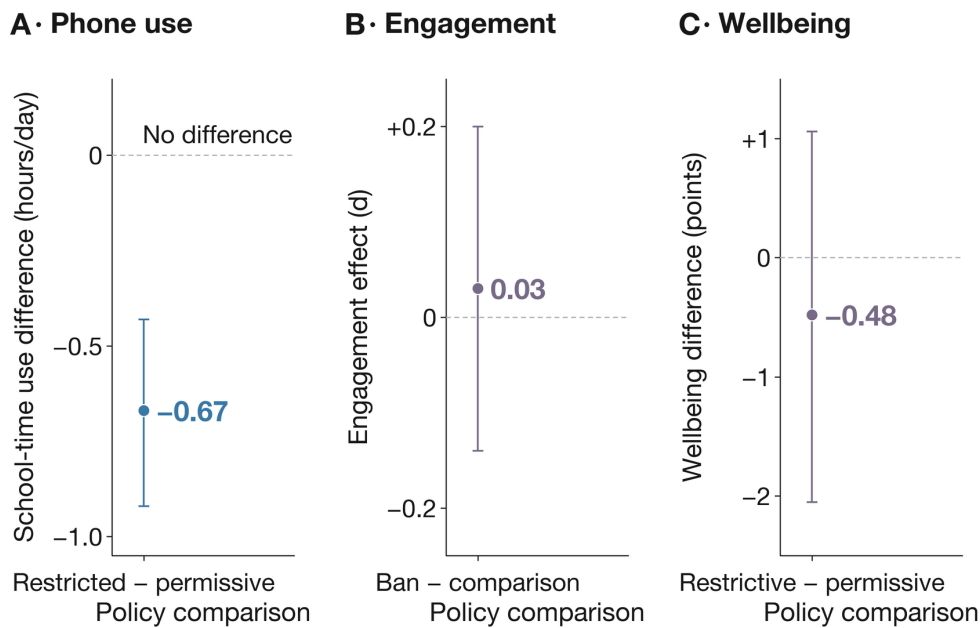


Figure 1. Restrictions align with less school-time use, not clear outcome gains. In panel A, the x-axis contrast is restricted minus permissive schools and the y-axis is school-time phone-use difference in hours/day: -0.67 (95% confidence interval -0.92 to -0.43). Panel B compares ban with comparison schools on academic engagement, standardized effect d 0.03 (-0.14 to 0.20). Panel C compares restrictive with permissive schools on adjusted wellbeing points, -0.48 (-2.05 to 1.06). Points are estimates, vertical whiskers are 95% confidence intervals, and dashed lines mark zero. These observational comparisons and short natural experiments do not provide a randomized long-term causal verdict.^{1,4,5,6}

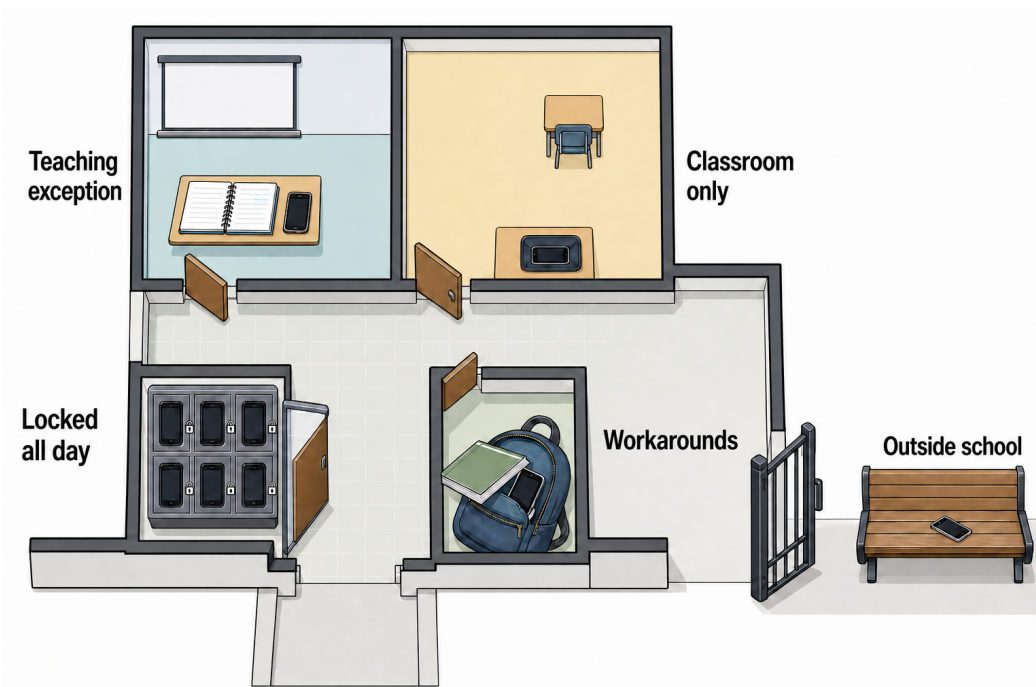


Figure 2. The policy label hides the intervention pupils experience. The same “phone ban” can mean locked all-day storage, classroom-only limits, teaching exceptions, or a rule that pupils work around; the school boundary also makes clear that none of these policies directly governs access outside the gate. The map compares implementation and spatial scope. It does not rank the components or imply which policy works best.^{5,7,11,6}

Read the figures together: one separates immediate from downstream outcomes; the other separates policy label from implementation.

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